

A New Chapter with New Things

In a lovely home in Frankfurt, there lived a girl named Clara Sesemann. Clara was sick. She spent most of her time in a wheelchair, which let her move around from room to room. Her favorite room was the study, filled with many bookcases. This is where she also took her lessons.

At the moment, Clara was waiting for something. Her blue eyes kept glancing at the clock. Finally, she asked, “Miss Rottenmeier, isn’t it time yet?”

Miss Rottenmeier was the housekeeper. She had been taking care of Clara since her mother passed away. Miss Rottenmeier wore an unusual uniform with a long cape and a tall hat. Clara’s father was often away, and he left Miss Rottenmeier in charge of the house. He only demanded that Clara be given whatever she wished for.

Finally, a young woman arrived at the front door with a little girl named Heidi. The young woman, Heidi’s aunt Deta, asked the coachman if they could go upstairs. He told her to speak to the butler instead. The butler, whose name was

Sebastian, soon appeared. He was wearing a coat with shiny brass buttons. Deta asked to see Miss Rottenmeier. Sebastian directed her to call for Tinette, the maid.

Tinette, wearing a bright white cap, came down the stairs. She asked them a bit rudely, “What do you want?” After Deta asked again to see Miss Rottenmeier, Tinette went upstairs.

Following Tinette, Deta and Heidi entered the study. Deta stayed near the door holding Heidi’s hand.

Miss Rottenmeier slowly walked over to them. She didn’t look very happy when she saw Heidi. Heidi was wearing her old straw hat and a red shawl, and the girl looked silly to the housekeeper. Heidi was staring at her fancy headpiece. “What is your name?” Miss Rottenmeier asked Heidi.

“Heidi,” she answered clearly.

“What kind of name is that? What did they call you when you were baptized?” Miss Rottenmeier asked.

“I don’t remember,” Heidi replied.

The housekeeper shook her head, puzzled. “Is she just ignorant or is she being sassy?”

“I’ll explain for her,” said Deta, after giving Heidi a little tap for her improper answer. “Heidi has never been in big, fancy houses like this one. She doesn’t know the proper way to act yet. Please forgive her. Her real name is Adelheid, after her mother. Adelheid was my sister.”

“Oh, that makes more sense. But the child seems a bit unusual for her age. I thought I told you that she needed to be twelve years old like Miss Clara. They need to be able to study together. How old is she really?” Miss Rottenmeier





Tinette stops Deta and Heidi at the door



demanded.

“I’m sorry, she’s a bit younger than I thought. I think she’s about ten,” Deta responded.

“I’m eight years old,” Heidi said then. Deta gave her a little tap again, but Heidi wasn’t sure why.

“Only eight!” exclaimed Miss Rottenmeier. “How will this work? What have you learned? What books have you read?”

“None,” Heidi replied.

“But how did you learn to read?” the housekeeper asked.

“I can’t read, and neither can my friend Peter,” Heidi answered.

“You can’t read?” Miss Rottenmeier gasped in surprise. “What have you studied then?”

“Nothing,” Heidi said honestly.

Miss Rottenmeier turned to Deta, upset, “How could you bring her here?”

Deta replied confidently, “I’m sorry for the misunderstanding. I thought Heidi would be a good fit here. Younger children can be less spoiled and more genuine. I have to go now. My employer is waiting. I’ll come back soon to check on Heidi.” With that, Deta quickly left the house. Miss Rottenmeier chased after her.

Heidi was still standing in the same spot. Clara had watched the whole conversation. She called to Heidi now to come to her.

Heidi approached the wheelchair.

“Do you want to be called Heidi or Adelheid?” asked



Clara.

“My name is Heidi.”

“I’ll call you Heidi then. I’ve never heard the name before, but I like the name very much,” said Clara. “Your hair is so curly! Was it always like that?”

“I think so.”

“How do you like Frankfurt?” Clara asked.

“It’s fine, but I’m going home again tomorrow. I’m going to bring Grandmother some soft white rolls,” Heidi explained.

“What a strange child you are,” said Clara. “You’re here in Frankfurt to stay with me, don’t you know that? We’re going to have our lessons together. I think it will be really fun when you learn to read. Mornings are pretty boring because Mr. Candidate comes at ten and stays until two. That’s a long time. He gets so tired he starts yawning while teaching the lessons. Miss Rottenmeier and he both yawn together behind their books. But when I do it, Miss Rottenmeier makes me drink cod liver oil and says I’m getting sick. So I have to pretend I’m not yawning because I hate that oil. It’s going to be so fun when you learn to read!”

Heidi shook her head doubtfully.

“Everybody has to learn to read, Heidi. Mr. Candidate is very patient and will explain it all to you. You won’t know what he means at first, because it’s difficult to understand him. It won’t take long, though. You’ll be understanding everything he says before you know it.”

After trying to find Deta to take Heidi back, Miss Rot-



tenmeier returned to the children. She had asked to have Heidi brought to the house to be Clara’s companion. Now she didn’t know what to do next. Frustrated, Miss Rottenmeier went into the dining room to fuss at the staff. Then, she returned to the children. Sebastian, the butler with the shiny brass buttons, followed close behind. As Sebastian stood next to Clara’s chair, he saw Heidi looking at him carefully.

Heidi said, “You look like Peter.”

Miss Rottenmeier didn’t like that comment. She quickly sent everyone to the dining room. After Clara was helped onto her dining chair, Miss Rottenmeier sat next to her. Heidi was asked to sit across from Miss Rottenmeier.

Heidi noticed a bread roll on her plate, and asked Sebastian, “Can I have this?” She trusted Sebastian because he reminded her of Peter. Sebastian smiled and nodded. When Heidi tucked the bread into her pocket, Sebastian could hardly keep from laughing.

Then, he brought Heidi a plate of small baked fish. Heidi wasn’t sure what to do. She looked at Sebastian and asked, “Must I eat that?”

Sebastian nodded again.

After some hesitation, Heidi asked, “Why don’t you give it to me?” She was trying to figure out how to get the food onto her plate. Again trying not to laugh, Sebastian put the plate on the table and left the room. Miss Rottenmeier then showed Heidi how to serve herself. She told her not to talk to Sebastian unless she really needed to. She also explained how Heidi should talk to the other servants. And she made



*Heidi sits at the Sesemann's dinner table*

sure Heidi knew she could call Clara by her first name.

Miss Rottenmeier gave Heidi many rules about how to behave. She taught her how to close doors, how to go to bed, and many other things. Heidi was so tired from waking up early that morning that she couldn't keep her eyes open any longer. She fell asleep right there in her chair.

When Miss Rottenmeier finished giving instructions, she said, "I hope you will remember everything, Adelheid."

But Clara, amused, replied, "Heidi went to sleep a long time ago."

"It's horrible the things I have to put up with when dealing with this child," exclaimed Miss Rottenmeier. She rang the bell with all her might, which called the servants. They had a hard time waking up Heidi to take her to her bedroom.